

Writing your Thesis at the Professorship for Innovation and Technology Management

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You can write your thesis at the Professorship for Innovation and Technology Management (TIM) in two ways. First, we either advertise topics in our courses or provide them upon request. Second, you may apply directly with us to write on your own topic. In either case, you should follow the application as it is explained in this document. It also includes the process following which we will assist you in completing your thesis.

1. Application

If you want to write your thesis with us, we expect you to send us an application with a cover letter. The cover letter should show your motivation, to write your thesis on the **specific topic** and **with us**. In addition, we expect a **current CV**, including an **up-to-date academic record**.

Should more students apply to one topic or the applications we receive exceed our capacity, the election process will be as follows:

- (1) Successful completion of core subjects in your degree program
- (2) Successful completion of courses that qualify you for scientific work (i.e., TIM Seminar)
- (3) Motivation and other qualifications
- (4) Personal circumstances

After you have been assigned a topic by us following a successful application, the first step is to submit a first "draft outline". Accordingly, we expect to see substantial engagement with **academic literature** already when submitting the outline, including (but not limited to) a list

of key references. We will then work with you to advance the draft outline into an enhanced version.

We do not accept papers that are exclusively practical. The reason is simple: university education should qualify you to see general patterns in specific problems. So, simply solving a concrete problem from practice should not be a big challenge for you. However, this does not disqualify you from writing papers in cooperation with a company. Nevertheless, scrutinizing a specific problem to understand how it is representative of a general class of problems and how solving this one problem enriches our understanding of solving any instance of this class of problems means that you have the potential to contribute to an academic debate.

2. Procedure

The application process is as follows. In the first step, we check the completeness of your documents, and then we check whether the selection criteria are fulfilled. If the assessment is positive, you will be informed about this by a short-written feedback on your application. We invite you to an interview to discuss your application in detail. We expect you to take this feedback to heart and incorporate it into an initial outline of your thesis and a solid idea of how you intend to carry it out. We will meet at a second interview date if progress should be sufficient. Please note, however, that we will start this meeting by registering your thesis - if you come to a second meeting, you will need to write your thesis with us.

The following is about feedback discussions during and after the thesis. Depending on the type and scope of your thesis, there will be **a maximum amount of feedback meetings**. We recommend you collect questions in advance to address them all at once in a meeting. You should also allow sufficient time beforehand to prepare your thesis and do basic research on your topic. For empirical work, we also provide feedback on core documents (interview guidelines, surveys, etc.). In addition, we offer every student the opportunity to have a feedback discussion after completing the thesis. Our responsibility is to advise you, but if it becomes apparent that we are the ones writing your thesis, this will have a negative impact on your grade. If this should be the case, we will inform you on time.

You are free to write your thesis in either English or German, unless explicitly stated different in the advertised topics. To ensure the highest level of compliance with the rules of good scientific practice at TUM, every thesis is checked for plagiarism and the massive use of generative AI.

3. Formalities

3.1 General Remarks

The **length** of a bachelor thesis is 30 (± 10 %), and for a master thesis 70 (± 10 %) pages, which refers only to the text part, including illustrations, tables, and graphics, whereby directions and appendix are excluded from the limits. The scope of each chapter should be balanced equally, with the focus on the main part (Theoretical Background, Results, Discussion). It is no longer required to submit theses in printed form, thus a digital version is sufficient in any case. **The submission of the thesis is done via upload to the portal. This will also determine whether the thesis has been submitted on time. All required information and the upload link will be provided after thesis registration.** Additional data should be provided via USB flash /cloud drive (after consultation with supervisor).

About the **format**:

- Margins: left: 2 cm; right: 2 cm; top: 2 cm; bottom: 2 cm
- Font: Times New Roman (12 pt.) or Arial (11 pt.); headline font size may differ
- Line spacing: 1.5
- Alignment: Justified (*German: "Blocksatz"*)
- Page numbering:
 - Directories (all except bibliography)
 - Consecutive Roman numerals
 - Text with subsequent bibliography and appendix - consecutive Arabic numerals
- Footnotes:
 - Font size: 10 pt.
 - Line spacing: 1 within footnotes, 1.5 between footnotes
 - Line break: indent next line (hanging)

The **structure** should logically be subdivided into three parts: Introduction, main part, and conclusion. It should not "jump"! Each main section starts at a new page. The exact structure will be discussed with the supervisor.

Regarding the **language**: The formulation should be clear and unambiguous, with no lengthy sentences, clear definitions of essential terms, and no colloquial language.

The **style** should be linguistically independent, and no "retelling" of studies.

3.2 Guidelines

About the **outline**:

- Arabic numbering (1, 1.1, 1.1.2, ...) without punctuation after the last digit
- 1, 2, 3, 4, ... is not particularly clear - use sub-level structure (1.1, 1.2, etc.)
- The structure should not be too detailed, e.g., two pages of outline are too much for 15 pages of text. A maximum of 3 sub-levels should be used for final theses. Find a good average!
- Headings should be meaningful and not general.

You should be careful with **enumerations**. They should only be used occasionally and if needed. A continuous text is optimal, supplemented by expressive graphics and occasional (economical and deliberate!) highlighting. Make paragraphs when you start a new train of thought within a chapter (a new line is not a paragraph).

Footnotes are "foot" notes and are placed "at the bottom" of the page, not at the end of the entire thesis. Further explanations, which are not necessary for a proper understanding of the text and information on further literature, should be placed as a footnote.

Figures and tables should have consecutive numbering and include a title, for example, Figure 1: Potential sources of innovation. The exact indication of sources is obligatory, for example:

- *Source: Own representation.*
- *Source: Own presentation (based on von Hippel (2005, p. 260)).*
- *Source: von Hippel (2005, p. 260).*

Do not embed figures in the text – always separate figures with respective numbering and source indication.

Abbreviations should not be used extensively in the running text. Common abbreviations (cf. Duden), such as "e.g." are permissible and not to be indicated in the list of abbreviations. Permitted abbreviations that need to be included in the list of abbreviations have to be written out when occurring in the running text for the first time - afterward, abbreviation shall be used:

- Example: First occurrence → European Patent Association (EPA); afterwards → EPA
- Common abbreviations in the scientific community or specific to the field, e.g., Artificial Intelligence (AI)
- Common abbreviations of institutions, organizations, or companies, e.g., United Nations (UN)

Furthermore, using abbreviations for convenience is not permitted, and the list of abbreviations should be sorted in alphabetical order.

The thesis should comprise the listed **directories (Document directory)** (if relevant) in the following order:

- Cover Sheet
- Blocking Note (only if applicable)
- Abstract (in German and English if the paper is written in German)
- Table of Contents
- List of Figures
- List of Tables
- List of Appendices
- List of Abbreviations
- List of Symbols
- Bibliography (after the text part)
- Declaration of Authorship

Moreover:

- Each directory is on a separate page.
- The directories do not include a sub-level structure.
- The bibliography should be clearly laid out (e.g., indentations, paragraphs).
- The table of contents contains page numbers.
- The list of figures is a directory; therefore, it is included in the table of contents of the theses with all other directories. It does not contain any figures, only titles of figures and respective page numbers.

3.3 Citation Rules

Please download the citation guide <https://www.ub.tum.de/en/citation-guide>. The **citation style APA** is preferred.

4. Last but not least:

- Develop **milestones** to get a time overview and avoid time bottlenecks. Allow enough time for revision, formatting, and printing, especially if you want others to review your thesis.
- Create a **literature overview** so you do not lose sight of the big picture, and manage your literature with a **reference management program**, e.g., "Citavi" or "Zotero."
- Always **save your thesis externally**, e.g., on a USB or cloud drive. You would still have a copy if your laptop/PC loses data (which is rare but can happen).
- Make sure to acknowledge and specify **any use of AI-related tools**, if applicable.
- **Keep in touch with your supervisor** to clarify any questions.

Good luck!